



## The Obligation Mosaic: Race and Social Norms in US Political Participation

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<https://doi.org/10.7208/chicago/9780226812434.001.0001>

Published: 27 January 2022

Online ISBN: 9780226812434

Print ISBN: 9780226812267

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### CHAPTER

## Three Which Norms?

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<https://doi.org/10.7208/chicago/9780226812434.003.0003> Pages 40–62

Published: 27 January 2022

### Abstract

Which norms matter for political participation in the United States? How do they vary across race, if at all? Using the method of grounded theory development, this chapter uses qualitative interviews with Black Americans and Asian Americans to identify participatory social norms that may shape orientations towards politics. Two norms are identified: the honoring ancestors norm and helping hands norm. The interviews reveal that both norms are strongly held across groups, but their expression—that is, the behavior that shows compliance with the norm—varies by group. While many Black Americans interviewed believe that honoring the past and helping those in need requires political involvement, these sentiments were less common among Asian Americans, who see other behaviors including continuing cultural traditions as the actions demanded by the norms.

**Keywords:** [grounded theory](#), [interviews](#), [Black Americans](#), [Asian Americans](#), [participatory social norms](#), [honoring ancestors](#), [helping hands](#), [cultural traditions](#), [civic duty](#), [political participation](#)

**Subject:** [US Politics](#)

**Collection:** [Chicago Scholarship Online](#)

The combination of divergent group histories and continued racial segregation suggests that norms about political participation likely vary across racial groups in the United States. This is the first testable implication of the racialized norms model, one on which the remaining claims hinge. Still for us to determine, though, is *which* social norms matter for political participation and how we expect them to vary.

How should we go about identifying these norms? One option is to look at previous scholarship, but there, surprisingly, we find a void. Extant work on the social norms of political participation has focused on *civic duty*, or a sense of obligation to the state (e.g., Blais, 2000). This appears first in a piece by Riker and Ordeshook (1968), who introduce the *D term* into the calculus of voting. This variable captures the psychological incentives

to participate ranging from “the satisfaction from compliance with the ethic of voting” to “affirming one’s allegiance to the political system” (8). Work inspired from this original instantiation has continued to imagine participatory social norms as primarily encompassing a sense of duty to the political system (Blais, 2000; Blais and Achen, 2019) or has simply asserted the existence of a civic duty norm when leveraging social sanctions (e.g., Gerber, Green, and Larimer, 2008). As a result, the existing taxonomy of social norms related to political participation is quite limited.

But we face another challenge in relying on extant scholarship: it is based almost entirely on White people. Much like the political behavior canon more broadly (García Bedolla, 2019), this work asserts generalizable conclusions based on mostly White samples that either control for or drop racial minorities out of the analyses entirely (Masuoka and Junn, 2013). If we base our hypotheses about which norms matter ↵ for participation on this work, we build in the assumption that the same things that matter to White people matter to all people. The components of the racialized norms model—along with other work in race, ethnicity, and politics—suggest this is at best a false assumption and at worst a dangerous one (Barreto and Segura, 2009; García Bedolla, 2019; Masuoka and Junn, 2013).

And so if extant literature provides little guidance on which social norms matter for political participation or intuition about how they vary across groups, where might we look instead?

I turn to the thoughts and insights of everyday people. A rich literature in sociology, race, ethnicity, politics, and political theory has, for some time, argued that centering the voice of nonacademics can generate new theory that is grounded in a lived reality rather than the ivory tower (Ackerly et al., 2018; Glaser and Strauss, 1967; Harris-Lacewell, 2010; Walsh, 2008). This approach to theory development is inductive in nature—it builds generalizations by examining specific cases rather than testing assertions in gathered data (Charmaz, 2014). As a result, grounded theory development is ideal for our purposes, letting us skirt a number of extant issues. We can investigate norms among non-White groups and generate new theory about how these norms vary without being limited to the concept of civic duty previously dominating the field. Following this inductive approach, we can later return to deductive scholarship, testing whether our generalizations materialize in largescale empirical data.

To build a grounded theory of participatory social norms, I use original interviews with twenty-three Black and Asian Americans living in metropolitan areas across the United States. My interviews were designed to unearth—rather than to test for—social norms related to political participation. I asked respondents to tell me about the guiding principles of their lives, their role models, the impetus for their choices in career and leisure activities, and their relationship to their communities. Through these interviews, I generate ideas about the norms perceived to shape Americans’ lives and when, if ever, these norms connect to political participation. I then use a two-step coding process to analyze these interviews, looking for patterns and insights that might generalize (Charmaz, 2014).

My results suggest that two social norms in particular shape attitudes about the value and meaning of political participation across racial groups in the United States. The first, the *honoring ancestors norm*, captures ↵ a prescriptive commitment to honor the sacrifices, struggles, stories, and traditions of those in the past, especially ancestral community members who paved the way for opportunities in the present. The second, the *helping hands norm*, embodies the notion that people should take care of others who are most in need. These two norms centrally orient the life choices and beliefs of Black and Asian Americans alike but vary in their connection to political participation. Reflecting group histories and resource realities, Black Americans often tie these norms to political involvement, suggesting that the way one honors the past is through claiming the political rights once denied to the group and that the best way to help people in need includes grassroots political change. Asian Americans, in contrast, argue for the fulfillment of these norms through continuing cultural traditions, seeking economic stability, and helping others around them through direct service. Neither group’s behavioral interpretations of core social values are normatively better or worse, but they are different.

And if the implications of the racialized norms model are correct, these differences may have far-reaching implications not just for political attitudes but also for political behavior.

## The Method of Grounded Theory

Although encompassing a rich history in other fields, grounded theory development is relatively uncommon in political behavior research. This is likely due to a number of factors: the causal revolution in the social sciences, the spread of survey sampling techniques, and an epistemological emphasis on generalizability (Coleman, 1986; García Bedolla, 2019; Mahoney, 2006). But grounded theory is a rigorous methodology with the ability to produce novel insights in previously understudied areas (Charmaz, 2014). As a result, some of the most influential books in the social sciences—books that have gone on to produce cottage industries of empirical work—are based in qualitative methodologies (e.g., Bonilla-Silva, 2017; Cramer, 2016; Waters, 1990).

Because of its rarity, however, the method of grounded theory may require some introduction. Grounded theory involves taking an inductive, iterative approach to knowledge development based on qualitative interviews or ethnographic data (Charmaz, 2014). The value of grounded theory lies in its reliance on the voice of everyday people to generate ideas about how the world works (Michener, 2018). During the process of collecting data, the researcher uses a method of coding to apply analytical categories to each segment of text. Over the course of the data collection process, the analyst refines these categories and pulls generalizable concepts from the data set that can then either stand alone or be used as hypotheses for further empirical work. Because the data collection and analyses are done concurrently in grounded theory development, interview protocols are flexible, with questions posed in later interviews responding to earlier data collection findings (Charmaz, 2014).

I apply this methodology to twenty-three original interviews conducted between May 2014 and December 2017. My interview subjects are US citizens at least eighteen years of age who identify as either Black or Asian American and speak fluent English. My choice to interview members of these two racial groups is based in both theoretical and practical reasons. Practically, qualitative interviewing is time intensive,<sup>1</sup> and from the start of the project, I knew my research would involve not just qualitative interviews but large-*N* empirical data as well. Excellent examples of fully qualitative treatises abound (e.g., Bonilla-Silva, 2017; Jiménez, 2010; Waters, 1990), but my interest in understanding how norm variation connects to national turnout trends and patterns of political participation meant that eventually my work would return to survey data.

Furthermore, my focus for the qualitative portion of the project was to identify norms that might matter for political participation in the United States and vary across groups. This meant that over the course of my interviews, I had to be able to observe norm differences that I could later use to develop survey measures and experiments. Small differences, even if present, might be difficult to identify with the relatively few interviews I planned to complete. So I selected the two groups for which I expected to observe the largest degree of variation: Black and Asian Americans. Examining these two groups holds constant the minority status of the population but exploits a dimension of difference I care deeply about: the propensity to engage. Previous scholarship has shown repeatedly that Black Americans often participate at relatively high rates both in the aggregate and when controlling for socioeconomic resources, while Asian American turnout is significantly lower despite the group's on-average high level of resources (File and Crissey, 2012; Fraga, 2018; Uhlaner, Cain, and Kiewiet, 1989). Examining these two groups, I hoped, would help me identify norms that varied across American racial groups more generally.

My search for research participants took place in three areas of the country: the San Francisco Bay Area; the Washington, DC, metropolitan area; and Nashville, Tennessee. I recruited participants through a combination of referrals and direct requests. About half the interviews were generated by asking people in my network to refer me to people they knew—whom I did not—who fit the criteria. This included my acquaintances'

colleagues, friends, classmates, and fraternity brothers, all of whom were at least two degrees of social separation away from me. The other half came from leveraging random interactions with strangers in my daily life. I recruited one participant from a recreational boxing class, another after a Craigslist exchange, and a third from the post office. My selection of locations was again based on both practical and theoretical reasons. In designing my protocol, I worried that completing interviews in regions where I could only be for short periods of time would mean I had to target elites or contact individuals through preexisting community organizations. By interviewing in regions where I lived, worked, or had family, my recruitment of participants could meander, leveraging random interactions or snowballing through contacts.

At the end of the process, I had completed fifteen interviews with Black Americans and eight with Asian Americans. The vast majority of these took place in person in public libraries, individuals' workplaces, conference rooms, and coffee shops, but three were conducted over the phone. At first glance, these numbers may seem relatively small and difficult to generalize from. Indeed, if I were writing a full-length book on simply these cases, careful scholars of qualitative methodology would likely be concerned. The methodological standard of the field is to interview to the point of "saturation," or where the same principles are repeated over and over across interviews. For some of the best qualitative books in the social sciences, this often involves between fifty and one hundred interviews (see Bonilla-Silva, 2017; Jiménez, 2010; Waters, 1990), but research suggests the actual saturation points are actually much lower, estimated at around thirteen interviews (Guest, Bunce, and Johnson, 2006). Furthermore, scholarship like mine that uses qualitative interviews simply to generate hypotheses—rather than as the end of the line of inquiry—often settles on much fewer cases (e.g., Carter, 2019).

p. 45 My small number of interviews, though, means this exploration should not be thought of as a statistical sample in any sense of the concept. In fact, my respondents are generally better educated but younger than the average American, likely reflecting the social spaces where they were recruited.<sup>2</sup> What these interviews do give us, though, is depth. People  are complicated, wonderfully so, and talking with them can reveal a lot about the cross-pressures they face on a daily basis, how they experience the world, and the knotted mixtures of motivations that drive behavior. Having sorted through all these complexities, we can turn to generating novel theories, ideas, and hypotheses for testing in nationally representative samples. So have patience, young grasshopper; we'll get to tests of generalizability and statistical significance in chapters 4–7.

Grounded theory is based on inductive principles—one begins with observations and draws generalizable principles from there rather than the other way around—but as the previous chapter suggests, I was already working within a theoretical framework. I knew I cared about norms and I had read quite a lot by the start of these interviews about how they develop and are enforced, measured, and observed. And I expected these norms to vary across groups. My interview protocol and subsequent analyses were informed, then, by these social psychological principles and hypotheses. But induction still played a role in my theorizing. I entered the study without extant hypotheses about *which* norms mattered, *how* they varied, or *what* the social contexts were that shaped their divergence.

My initial protocol was designed to ask questions about people, feelings, and beliefs that likely influenced behavior either through social rewards (injunctive norms) or by invoking cognitive dissonance (personal norms). I began each interview with questions that were explicitly apolitical, asking respondents about sources of pride, concepts of success, characteristics of role models, and requirements of group membership. My hope was that these questions would reveal information about the social expectations of groups and whether any of these expectations was tied to political participation. Importantly, I did not want to begin with questions about political participation and see how people defended their choice to be active or not but rather to examine core normative concepts and see whether any of these brought respondents *to* politics. I was interested in both what was connected to political participation and what was not, with absence being as telling as presence. My protocol was flexible and changed over time. Responses to early interviews shaped the questions I asked in later interviews as patterns emerged pointing to the types of norms I should be paying attention to.<sup>3</sup>

p. 46 After my first few interviews—three in a row with young Asian American women in the Bay Area—I thought I was not getting anything. These women’s lives were fascinating, and our conversations revealed ↪ rich insights about gender roles, parental expectations, immigration, and work ethics, but there was no talk of political participation. It was not usually until the end of the interviews when I finally—desperately—prompted them, that I got some basic information of their political histories and views. At the time, I could not figure out what to do with this information, and I started to doubt the process. Were my questions too vague? I wondered. Was my approach of focusing on apolitical topics in hopes of uncovering, rather than leading to, participatory social norms the wrong one? The initial set of seventy-four codes, derived by handcategorizing these three interviews passage by passage, included everything from “sons vs. daughters” to “home country” to “hobbies.”

It was not until I began coupling these interviews with responses from Black Americans that the clear parallels and political ramifications started to emerge. Respondents across racial groups cared fundamentally about the same things: they loved their families, respected the sacrifices of those in the past, sought economic security, wished to help others, and desired a life of meaning. However, when placed in the context of bigger, structural features that shaped these groups’ histories, opportunities, and experiences, the behaviors attached to these motivations were often distinct. How one honored the past depended, fundamentally, on what had happened in the past; helping those in need was shaped greatly by who was imagined as needy.

From the total eighty-two codes I applied in the full coding of early interviews, an emergent theory developed: groups shared a number of core, fundamental norms, but their interpretation—the behavioral ramifications—varied. With this central concept in mind, both I and a graduate research assistant returned to the data, independently coding the transcripts again, now with a radically reduced seventeen codes in use. Through this process, I identified two social norms with broad ramifications for political participation in the United States: the *honoring ancestors* and *helping hands* norms. Both Black and Asian Americans discussed the importance—socially and personally—of honoring the past and helping others, but only Black Americans connected these concepts to political participation. Work in psychology and anthropology suggests values like these may be universal, transcending place and peoples (Graham et al., 2013; Hefner, 1991; Schwartz, 1992; Steadman, Palmer, and Tilley, 1996), but I find that the interpretations, social expectations, and behavioral habits that derive from these beliefs—that is, the social norms of groups—are heavily dependent on context. Specifically, honoring the

p. 47 ↪ past and helping others have group-specific schemas that matter for who shows up and turns out in the political sphere.

## The Honoring Ancestors Norm

The importance of honoring the past came up repeatedly in my conversations with Black and Asian Americans, but who ancestors were and what was required in the process of honoring them varied significantly. I found that a basic, widely shared value to recognize and respect the stories, struggles, and traditions of those in the past took on group-specific meaning, responding to history and group membership. Black Americans often saw honoring the past as requiring the claiming of civil and political rights their ancestors had fought for over the course of generations. Asian Americans, on the other hand, were more likely to connect the honoring ancestors norm to cultural activities and financial success, grounded in ancestors of other nations and those who had immigrated seeking the American dream. Despite both groups showing strong normative commitments to honoring the past—naming this value continually as a guiding principle in their lives—the meaning of “honor your ancestors” was heavily community dependent; who ancestors are matters for how groups honor them.

Ancestors and the importance of honoring the past seemed to be an ever-present topic on the minds of individuals I talked with. Asked about how they spent their leisure time, respondents mentioned ancestors;



asked about how they got their name, respondents mentioned ancestors; asked about their careers, respondents mentioned ancestors. Black and Asian Americans alike talked about “being mindful of where your people come from,” feeling a duty “to a whole heritage,” “living up to my traditions,” and feeling “a connection to the land” of their ancestors. References to the past and to ancestors came in two forms: familial and imagined (Anderson, 2006). Mentions of “my grandmother” were as common as “my people,” sewn together into a single concept of those in the past who sacrificed, paved the way, and built traditions.

p. 48 However, each group’s historical context shaped how Black and Asian Americans envisioned their ancestors and the corresponding behaviors that were required for the process of honoring. As a result, a single, shared value about “honoring the past” took on group-specific interpretations, informed by the group’s historical experiences and narrative of the past. Specifically, Black Americans, a group with roots connecting back to the very founding of the nation, often argued that honoring the past required claiming the rights—political, educational, and economic—their ancestors had fought for over the course of centuries. Asian Americans, on the other hand, a group for whom the majority of members are either first- or second-generation immigrants, were more likely to connect the honoring ancestors norm to cultural activities and financial success, drawing from the traditions of other nations and the hopes of their immigrant forebears.

## Honoring Ancestors among Black Americans

Black Americans almost always located their ancestors in the United States and discussed the legacy of mass disenfranchisement and oppression of their group. Today, the vast majority of Black Americans in the United States have family ties reaching back to the era of slavery and Jim Crow.<sup>4</sup> These periods of harsh oppression subjected most group members to violence, poverty, and second-class citizenship. Reflecting this history, respondents discussed the “segregated South” their parents and grandparents grew up in and the “bias that goes back four hundred years that we are always gonna be deemed second class or not even citizens.” Regularly, Black respondents explicitly connected their ancestors to those “from the middle passage and slavery,” explaining, “We were never, ever meant or intended to be citizens.”

p. 49 But the Black people I talked with also discussed how their ancestors—familial and imagined—fought for incorporation into democratic citizenship. Black Americans saw their ancestors as struggling against mass oppression over the course of centuries in search of the franchise and other civil and political rights. Mentions of this history came up in topics as varied as career choices, fashion, the origin of respondents’ names, holiday dinner table stories, and the memory of grandparents. Black respondents regularly mentioned specific civil rights leaders when explaining their own behaviors and choices (“The other pair are Malcolm X glasses.... I get a lot of compliments on them”;<sup>5</sup> “Why the law?... I remember Martin Luther King”) and reified those who were involved in the civil rights struggle. For instance, Martin talked extensively about his grandmother, whom he calls “his light.” A thirty-two-year-old police officer who moonlights as a Methodist minister, Martin explains, “[My grandmother] had the courage to stand up against injustice... in a time where you could have lost your life.”<sup>6</sup> DeMarkus elaborates, “You have a people here who, their whole purpose for the whole time has been fighting just to be recognized as humans. Before that we weren’t even threefifths human.”

This concept of ancestors as people who struggled for political and civil rights influenced group norms about the appropriate ways to honor the past. Referencing both their own intrinsic motivations and the social expectations of their peers, Black Americans talked about political participation, specifically voting, and taking advantage of educational opportunities as central ways to honor their ancestors’ stories and sacrifices. Three remarkably similar statements about voting made by Black Americans living in different parts of the country exemplify this:

But I get out and vote because it’s the thing to do. Because I had people who fought for me to be able to vote, and I’m gonna exercise my rights.—Alexus, Nashville, TN

It disheartens me when I hear that people say, “Oh, I just didn’t have time to go out and vote.” I’m like, what do you mean? We went through so much just to get that right. Why would you not exercise it?—Martin, Washington, DC, metropolitan area

I think also, especially for me, being a Black woman, I think [voting] is so important, and I think it’s important in many groups, like women and people of color who have been denied voting rights in the past.... There’s so many people who have fought for this right and who actually, at some point, didn’t have this right.—Tisha, San Francisco Bay Area

Alexus, Martin, and Tisha all cite historical group exclusion and the struggle for enfranchisement as their primary impetus for voting. For many Black Americans, the duty they felt to vote was deeply connected with a concept of honoring the past. Their predecessors, both familial and in the broader sense of the group, had fought and died for the franchise. To not vote would be to disrespect the efforts of those brave men and women whose sacrifices expanded the franchise; it would be to show irreverence to a history of oppression and struggle.

p. 50 Both psychological orientations (personal norms) and social expectations (injunctive norms) motivated Black respondents to vote as a way to honor the past. Martin, for instance, discusses his decision to vote in 2008 for Barack Obama as motivated by his grandmother, a woman who had actively participated in the civil rights movement: “I can honestly say I thought that I owed it to my grandmother to have her see her dream before she died.” Martin goes on to explain, “You better not dare say anything to any older person that’s over fifty years old and say I’m not voting.... You would get thrown out. You might get beat down. [Laughs.] Because so many people were moved that night when they announced that [Barack Obama] had won. It was seeing the outcome of things that had been prophesied in the Bible. It was the Negro spiritual songs that were sung many years, ‘We Shall Overcome.’” In his comments, Martin highlights the social consequences of not appropriately honoring the legacy of the civil rights struggle as a Black American. He says that any person alive before the passage of the 1965 Voting Rights Act would “[get you] thrown out” for not voting.

Social norms theory suggests that external expectations like these are, over time, incorporated into a person’s sense of morality (Cialdini and Trost, 1998; Hogg, 2003; Mori, Chaiken, and Pliner, 1987). Socialization over a lifetime, including repeated exposure to group concepts of what is good and right, become personal norms (Thøgersen, 2006). Unlike injunctive norms that are motivated by the expectation of external, social benefits, these personal norms motivate behavior through a desire to avoid self-concept distress. Monica provides an example of how personal norms can shape behavior as she tells me about the one time she was unable to vote—the result of a bureaucratic snafu rather than a lack of effort: “I remember one year I didn’t vote. I had moved, and I guess I didn’t change my address [in time].... I was literally close to tears when they said I couldn’t vote because, I mean... I always [vote].”

Monica is not just a regular voter; she is a committed, passionate voter. She goes on to explain that her commitment to voting—her sense of “civic duty”—is based on the fact that voting is a right that many have lived without. She cites South African apartheid, saying, “I always think about after apartheid fell, and you would see those photographs, pictures of the lines of people in South Africa who, for the first time, could vote.”

p. 51 Both Monica and Martin identify value intrinsic to the process of voting as their reason for turning out. They vote not because they wish to influence the outcome of an election but rather because the act of voting honors a community of the past. Many Black Americans I talked with were suspicious of the American political system and felt voting was unlikely to produce high-quality representation for their community. The instrumental benefits at stake in any given election was not what brought them to the polls. Rather, they voted because they wished to honor the sacrifices and struggles of their ancestors. Tisha, for instance, explains, “I’m a pessimist by nature, so there was a part of me that was like, oh, voting doesn’t change anything,” but she votes because “people of color... have been denied voting rights in the past” and “there’s so many people who have fought for

this right.” Alexis similarly tells me, “Everybody knows politics is not voting. It’s already predesigned, prepicked,” but also, “I get out and vote because... I had people who fought for me to be able to vote.” Despite concerns about the effectiveness of voting and the responsiveness of the political system, the intrinsic value of honoring ancestral struggles propelled some Black Americans to the polls.

In addition to voting, Black Americans often connected educational opportunities to the honoring ancestors norm. Those in the past had been excluded from and fought for not just political rights but also access to a broader array of civic opportunities including the right to an education. As a result, honoring the past through fully embracing the rights and opportunities withheld from predecessors sometimes included a discussion of education. Black respondents often mentioned being the first member in their family to graduate from high school or college and discussed pursuing education and economic opportunities as part of the way to honor their ancestors’ struggles. One respondent told me, “There was a time where black people could be killed for reading.” Another revealed the following: “I think back upon the many lives that were lost for people, African Americans who tried to go and read and write, and were killed, were lynched just because they tried to get an education. And how dare me not think about that, take that into consideration. And now I have the opportunities that someone died for.... So I have a duty. Not just to me, but to a whole heritage, a whole race of people.”

Thus, for Black Americans, the honoring ancestors norm took on a very specific flavor. Informed by the group’s history, Black Americans often saw honoring the past as requiring the claiming of political rights through voting and civil rights by seeking out educational opportunities. These acts were prescriptively valued and socially rewarded. A duty to the state did not guide engagement in politics, nor did the possibility of instrumental rewards in the form of electoral outcomes. Rather, the value of voting for many was tied tightly to the goal of honoring the past and remembering the sacrifices and struggles of ancestors. To vote was to make good on a community-based social norm.

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## Honoring Ancestors among Asian Americans

Asian Americans were just as likely to talk about their ancestors in interviews, but their stories about the past and what they meant for their lives were different from those of Black Americans. Asian Americans have a history in the United States that dates back centuries; they helped build the transcontinental railroads, participated in the California gold rush, and were quarantined during the Second World War (Takaki, 2008). However, the vast majority of Asian Americans I talked with were either first-or second-generation citizens. Their nativity reflects demographic realities key to understanding the Asian American population in the United States today. The passage of the 1965 Immigration and Nationality Act served to dramatically revitalize and increase the number of Asian immigrants to the United States (Masuoka and Junn, 2013; Zong and Batalova, 2016). As a result, nearly 90% of Asian adults in the United States are either first-or second-generation citizens (see appendix C, table C.2).

The parents and grandparents of the Asian Americans I talked with had immigrated to the United States from nations as diverse as China, India, the Philippines, and Japan, sometimes with intermediary stops in other nations.<sup>7</sup> However, respondents were nearly unified in their discussions of immigration as a key defining feature in their lives. One respondent told me, “A story about myself is inevitably a story about my parents because I am a child of immigrants”; another said, “Immigration made my life possible.... To my parents I do owe a debt of gratitude, and I just really try to honor them in every way that I can.”

With shorter histories in the United States, Asian Americans often looked to their families’ ethnic country of origin when explaining their ancestors’ stories and discussed the sacrifices their parents and grandparents had made to give them opportunities available in the United States. As a result, Asian Americans often spoke of honoring the past by continuing cultural activities including learning musical instruments, serving certain



foods around holidays, and observing marital practices tied to their ancestors' home country. Samaira explains that learning classical South Asian music was a way "to have a much deeper connection to our home country." In continuing this heritage, she sees herself carrying on a "really rich musical tradition." Other respondents similarly discussed participating in ethnicity-based pageants as a way to remember their ancestors' legacy and the importance of language. Jonathan describes relearning Chinese in college after having lost much of the language as a child. "It was an act of reclamation," he says.

Aisha may best demonstrate the important personal and injunctive components of the honoring ancestors norm as tied to cultural practices and traditions. A twenty-five-year-old college graduate whose family immigrated to the Bay Area from India, Aisha chose to participate in an arranged marriage, which she believed was an important way to honor the traditions and culture of her family. She tells me, "I went through the whole arranged marriage process and that's a huge deal in our community. Arranged marriages have been in India for generations.... I'm not trying to brag or anything—but I've heard people say... 'People are so proud of what you did—going with what your parent said, going with the arranged marriage.'" Here, Aisha cites the very social nature of her choice—honoring her family's heritage of arranged marriages—brings her respect and social rewards in her community. Aisha compares this with a friend of hers who went against the wishes of her family to pursue a partnership outside the tradition of arranged marriages: "She ended up marrying a guy she fell in love with. Her parents were not very happy—you know, her mom is definitely not happy.... [Marrying someone outside the caste] messes up your community circle.... I'm sure she's happy and all, but you know there's some things that she can't participate in."

Aisha highlights the social exclusion that can come from choosing a path outside of the cultural traditions of her community. Like many Asian Americans I talked with, Aisha highlights the way she altered the tradition slightly by asking her parents to delay the process until she finished college. Asian Americans often balanced the cultural demands of honoring their ancestors with their desire for autonomy and American identity. But even with this balancing act, the importance of honoring ancestors through continuing cultural practices featured prominently.

Asian Americans also linked the honoring ancestors norm to financial success, citing their parents' and grandparents' sacrifices to immigrate to a country with economic and educational opportunities. Jonathan, an Ivy League graduate pursuing a medical degree, tells me, "[My parents] were top of their class back in China, and they came here for more opportunities, at least economic opportunities." Samaira's parents immigrated from India. She similarly explains, "The majority of South Asians immigrated to the US after the Immigration Act of 1965, in which period Americans really needed skilled labor.... And in order to be one of the really successful doctors for whom the gates to this country were thrown open, you had to be the very best.... Every single one of us had valedictorian parents.... And every single one of us is trying to live up to them." This concept of economic success as tied to honoring the sacrifices of ancestors came up repeatedly in discussions of goals and sources of pride. "Being successful," one respondent told me, "means being able to earn an income to support yourself and your family."

Unlike Black respondents, though, Asian Americans did not connect the honoring ancestors norm to political participation. For Black Americans, politics often came up organically with references to the struggle for the franchise, a common theme across interviews. For Asian Americans, this connection was almost never made. Despite the fact that Asian Americans have a rich history of both labor and political struggles in the United States (Takaki, 2008), most Asian respondents did not feel connected to this community or narrative. At the end of one of my final interviews, I asked an Asian American woman explicitly about this. She had spent much of the interview talking about the honoring ancestors norm, among other things. I asked her if she thought honoring her ancestors could ever require involvement in politics. She replied, "I don't think that my ancestors, particularly my grandparents and parents, would have thought of me being a very politically active person as something that they wanted for me. Only because I think that they think of political activism as a response to struggle. And so I think that they would think that my political activism means that I have something to be

politically active about, which means that I've struggled against something, which means that they haven't done their job."

The interview data suggest that group-specific interpretations of honoring ancestors may matter greatly for variation in political participation across groups. Shaped seemingly by the historical factors of immigration and integration into the American narrative, the honoring ancestors norm may require different actions for compliance based on group membership. Both Black and Asian Americans I talked with cared deeply about honoring the sacrifices and struggles of those who came before them, but how they went about doing so was shaped by the constraints and narratives of their groups. ↵

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**Table 3.1** Behaviors tied to honoring ancestors

|           | Black Americans | Asian Americans |
|-----------|-----------------|-----------------|
| Economic  | ✓               | ✓               |
| Political | ✓               |                 |
| Cultural  |                 | ✓               |

Table 3.1 summarizes variation in the behaviors tied to the honoring ancestors norm for each group. On average, Black and Asian Americans both tied educational and economic opportunities to the honoring ancestors norm. Both groups saw their predecessors as making sacrifices on these dimensions, providing present-day group members with these opportunities through their efforts. Whether one's community of the past was made up of recent immigrants from other nations or people fighting for equal rights in a country opposed to them, the sacrifices of ancestors often brought respondents to a prescriptive commitment to excel and care for their families economically. Systematically, I saw that both Asian and Black Americans were likely to cite the honoring ancestors norm as demanding that they pursue economic stability for their families, often through educational attainment.

Black and Asian Americans diverged, however, in connecting cultural and political behaviors to the norm. For Black Americans, honoring the past required claiming the political rights, especially the franchise, that the group's ancestors fought for. For Asian Americans, honoring the past required continuing the cultural traditions of their ancestors.<sup>8</sup> In both cases, respondents felt both psychological and social pressures to conform to these norms. But only in the case of Black Americans did the honoring ancestors norm lead to valuing, rewarding, and engaging in political participation.

## The Helping Hands Norm

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The second concept that appeared repeatedly in interviews but diverged in form and strength between the two groups was the helping hands norm. The helping hands norm encompasses the prescriptive commitment to help others, especially those in need. Black and Asian Americans alike discussed helping others as a central component of good citizenship and community membership, but the behaviors each group attached to the norm, and the norm's relative strength or priority, were different. Specifically, Black Americans were more likely to believe that helping those in need required coordinated political action and policy change. Asian Americans, on the other hand, were more likely to cite direct service and charitable activity. Furthermore, while Black Americans often located the helping hands norm as a central part of their sense of self and community, Asian Americans are more likely to restrain the helping norm, sometimes seeing it in conflict with components of the honoring ancestors norm. Speculating from the interview data, I argue this divergence may be the product of group orientations toward upward mobility and the extent of structural barriers to economic stability.

What does it mean to be a good citizen? Be a good community member? Black and Asian Americans alike almost always discussed the importance of taking care of people in need and helping around the community when asked such questions. A good citizen and community member looks outward, is conscious of his or her surroundings, and works to improve them. A good citizen lends a helping hand to those who need one. Referencing the helping hands norm, respondents told me about the value of "helping others who are less fortunate than you," choosing their careers because it was "a way to somehow get involved in improving life for people" and because treating others well was "the one rule I try to follow the most." Wrapping this concept in normative principles, they often told me that helping others was a deep source of pride for themselves and their families, and they saw success as tied to their ability to give back to their community.

However, the interpretation of the norm—and also, in this case, its relative strength—was dependent on group membership. In particular, Black Americans were more likely to couple political involvement and grassroots policy change with the helping hands norm, while Asian Americans more regularly discussed direct service. These differences appeared to be grounded in the groups' own experiences with economic struggles, discrimination, and perceptions about what was required to live a flourishing life. Furthermore, Black Americans often elevated the helping hands norm to a priority, even entangling it with the honoring ancestors norm. Asian Americans, on the other hand, sometimes saw the helping hands norm in conflict with the more important honoring ancestors norm and, as a result, placed caveats on its implementation.

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### Helping the Needy among Black Americans

The Black Americans I talked with often discussed taking care of those in need as a way to attain respect from others as well as a core organizing principle for their choices. When asked what it means to be successful, a number of Black respondents told me success includes "making a difference," "giving back to my community and where I came from," and "what you do for people." Helping others, especially those in need, was often what respondents were most proud of about themselves and what they believed others valued about them. For instance, Tisha explained, "I think [my parents] are really proud that I stuck to what I was passionate about, which is serving others."

When asked how exactly they take care of others or what the best ways to help people in need are, Black Americans regularly turned to community-based participation and policy change. Drawing from their own experiences and concerns over the group's struggles, Black Americans believed that helping others required engaging in the political sphere, especially at the local level. Doreen, Monica, and Tisha, three Black women I interviewed, provide examples:

My life has been about service. I've worked for the state, I've worked for a youth organization that helped kids whose parents were incarcerated, I've served Hurricane Katrina evacuees.... I've seen that direct service level piece.... And we still have the same problems. So not to take anything away from those endeavors and people in the community who have nonprofits that do those things, but I'm realizing more and more that in order to impact change, it needs to happen on the policy level. And if it's gonna happen on the policy level, I need to have a seat at the table to change it.... I want to have a say. I want to speak for those people, 'cause I've lived it.—Doreen, Nashville, TN

I want to change policy.... I can fight on the ground level all day, and I'm fine with doing that. I'm fine with helping everyday people. But then I also recognize how important actually changing the policies and the legislation in this country is. And so I think right now that's kind of where I'm leaning, is into going into policy and advocacy.—Tisha, San Francisco Bay Area

I think to be a good citizen, we want you to be gainfully employed so that you can pay taxes. Which is how we take care of people who don't have.... I realize so much more clearly now that [paying taxes] is the way that we care for not just those who are in need, but that's how we have roads, and that's why we have bridges, and we have all the things that we need.... I just thank God that I can pay taxes, because that's how we take care of [people].—Monica, Washington, DC, metropolitan area

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These three women, spread across the country, connected the helping hands norm not necessarily to voting but to more costly activism, including running for office, working on campaigns, and paying taxes. These respondents, among others, often commented on the value of not just governmental reform but also community-based reform. Many Black respondents stated that governmental intervention is problematic when its solutions are not rooted in the community or designed by people with relevant experience. They advocated for more grassroots approaches to policy change that “start at home.”

When explaining why helping others requires political participation, respondents often reached for both their own experiences and their group's experiences with structural disadvantage and discrimination. Tisha, for instance, talks about her family's and friends' negative interactions with the legal system when she was young and her own time in foster care. Pointing to these experiences, and explaining how a combination of race and class seemed to undermine fair outcomes, Tisha explains, “As I got older... I started participating in a lot of advocacy for foster youth and just learning that kids do have rights, and you're actually supposed to meet with your attorney... and just feeling like wow, I got [cheated], so how many other kids are out here getting [cheated] with crappy lawyers? And it's like, this isn't right.”

Tisha's comments reflect important empirical and historical realities about Black Americans' experiences in the United States. While the Voting Rights Act and the Civil Rights Act opened a world of economic and political opportunity once prohibited to Black Americans, they did nothing to compensate those same citizens for centuries of barriers to economic prosperity. Many have argued that, as a result, barriers to home ownership and exclusion from welfare opportunities that preceded these monumental pieces of legislation continue to haunt the economic stability of Black Americans today (e.g., Katznelson, 2006). Furthermore, Black Americans continue to face systematic barriers to employment and are disproportionately affected by punitive carceral state policies (Alexander, 2012; Pager, 2003; Pager and Shepherd, 2008; Western, 2006).<sup>9</sup>

In the face of these challenges, many Black respondents took a multidimensional approach to helping people in need, citing not just political participation but also charitable and religious action. For instance, Royce discusses a mission trip he took and how “doing physical labor... felt like I was actually changing people's lives.” Martin regularly cites the Bible when discussing helping others. “We need to get away from feeling like we're the victims of something,” he tells me, and “by going back to the church, through teaching and preaching, I think that we can do that. We can change the mindset of a people.”<sup>10</sup> As a result, there may be more diversity in the Black public's approach to the helping hands norm than there is in the honoring ancestors norm.

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## Helping the Needy among Asian Americans

Asian Americans also talked about helping others as a core component of community membership, but in a prioritized list of how they should spend their time, Asian Americans sometimes limited the reach of the helping hands norm and saw it as competing with other obligations. For instance, many Asian Americans told me it was important to “be realistic” about how they allocate their time and sometimes identified certain components of the honoring ancestors norm as in competition with the helping hands norm for their resources. With only so much time and energy available in a day, obligations to family and school or work came first. For instance, Amber explains that her parents were “more worried about me focusing on school” than community engagement but that if she did not “shirk [her] other duties,” they might support activities like helping others if she “felt strongly enough about it.” Lisa similarly tells me that “[my parents] want to make sure I keep myself realistic.... Be sure you can take care of yourself, and take care of your pets, whatever is in your care, and you’re free to pursue those things.”

When Asian Americans I talked with did elaborate on how they might take care of others in need, they spoke of individual acts of kindness or charity rather than political participation. These behaviors included opening doors for the elderly, providing food to the homeless, and being kind to strangers. Sometimes Asian Americans told me about how these individual-based actions could make larger, society-wide change through the “domino effect.” In discussing ways society can take care of people in need, Aisha describes the plot of an Indian movie she once watched: “I do something for you and you say, ‘Hey, thanks for...’ and I say, ‘No, I don’t want a thanks, I want you to go help three other people...’ So I think it just kinda ends up spreading out, it’s one of those—the domino effect, you know. One person tells three people, and then these three people tell three other people. It’s kinda multiplying like that. And that’s a very powerful message.” Similarly, Tala chronicles a YouTube video she saw just a few weeks prior to our interview: “It’s kinda like that domino effect—if you help someone, then in the future someone else would help you. This question kinda reminds me of this video I watched. [Describes video.] That was really inspiring—that video.” Both Aisha and Tala suggest that small acts of kindness rather than political participation can solve systemic social ills. When thinking of how to care for others in need, they identify primarily forms of direct service.

Some Asian Americans I talked with did identify political participation and policy change as the best way to help others, but they described these opinions as in conflict with the broader expectations of their community. Both Jonathan and Samaira, for instance, talked about “generational poverty” and “community advocacy” as defining their orientations toward helping others. But their communities, they explained, admired a different set of behaviors that they often saw themselves fighting against or being in conflict with. Jonathan tells me that in his experience, the Asian American community has “given into that perverse logic of the model minority myth, where you don’t need rights or don’t need civic engagement because the underhanded deal of the market or of society has treated you quite well.”

In this comment, Jonathan alludes to how immigration policy in particular has aided in the structural advancement of Asian Americans. Samaira, too, brings up this point in her interviews, discussing in detail the 1965 Immigration and Nationality Act. Known as the Hart-Celler Act, this monumental piece of legislation moved the nation’s immigration policy away from racially based quotas toward a system that gave priority to both family reunification and skilled labor (Masuoka and Junn, 2013). Since the policy change, the Asian American population has grown in the United States from 1.3 million to 18 million citizens, with an estimated 16 million able to immigrate as a direct result of this immigration reform (Lopez, Passel, and Rohal, 2015). Selection on skill and the growing number of visas tied to economic sponsorship have served to bring a particularly well-educated, well-resourced group of Asian Americans to the United States. In 2013, an estimated 57% of these newly arrived Asian immigrants had completed at least a bachelor’s degree, compared to only 30% of US-born adults (Lopez, Passel, and Rohal, 2015). In 2016, the median income for Asian American families was \$83,183, \$40,000 more than the national average for Black Americans and \$15,000 more than for White Americans (Fontenot, Semega, and Kollar, 2018).<sup>11</sup> Asian Americans and their families generally arrive in



p. 61 the United States equipped with a set of skills that allows them to engage successfully with the American labor market. ↵

**Table 3.2** Behaviors tied to helping the needy

|                | Black Americans (stronger) | Asian Americans (weaker) |
|----------------|----------------------------|--------------------------|
| Direct service | ✓                          | ✓                        |
| Political      | ✓                          |                          |
| Religious      | ✓                          |                          |

These differences in exposure to structural discrimination seem to orient respondents toward the helping hands norm. Grievances about inequity in the American legal, financial, and political systems lead Black Americans to translate the highly valued helping hands norm into political behaviors and practices, especially high-cost, local political activism. In contrast, the generally well-resourced and highly educated Asian Americans I talked with were less likely to see a connection between helping others and political participation. Rather, when discussing how to care for those in need, Asian Americans more often mentioned direct service to those around them. Further, the tenets of the helping hands norm seemed to conflict for some Asian Americans with the demands of the honoring ancestors norm. Helping others, especially outside the home, was perceived as a barrier to the financial and educational goals tied to honoring the sacrifices of those in the past. Drawing together these insights, table 3.2 presents the various behaviors groups connect to the helping hands norm and how they might vary in their connection across groups.

## Norms Broadly Held but Uniquely Construed

p. 62 A grounded theory approach to identifying participatory social norms brings to the fore two norms with possible implications for political participation: the honoring ancestors and helping hands norms. My analyses ↵ suggest that these norms are widely endorsed in the United States, crossing racial and ethnic boundaries but that they vary in their behavioral interpretations. A group’s history, narratives, constraints, and opportunities breathe life into these simple prescriptive concepts, giving them meaning. The resulting group-based content of the honoring ancestors and helping hands norms is a set of beliefs about how best to honor the past and take care of those in need, which also provide signals to others about compliance.

Sometimes these norms seem to demand political participation from group members. Rather than duty to the state or even the search for instrumental benefits, duty to one’s community of the past and to those most in need may animate the choice to engage in politics. These commitments appear to serve as guiding principles in a wide array of life choices, defined and reinforced by one’s social space, but are only sometimes coupled with political participation. Macro forces in the form of immigration law, integration into the American political system and narratives, and exposure to structural deprivation and discrimination appear to shape this coupling. As suggested by the RNM, the distinct directives and demands of one’s community are reflective of its history. We turn next to testing these concepts empirically and expanding our analyses to include not just Asian and Black Americans but each of the four largest racial groups in the United States.

## Notes

1. My interviews lasted on average one hour, but completing each also involved significant coordination, preparation, and travel time, not to mention the handful of cancellations and no-shows I experienced.
2. Appendix B provides a discussion of my interview collection process; a table available in the online appendix (see URL in appendix A) shows further demographic information about each respondent.
3. Appendix B provides a list of sample questions I used in my interviews; the online appendix provides a complete list of questions included in the various iterations of my protocol.
4. While it is difficult to assess the exact number of Black Americans today who had enslaved ancestors in the United States, an examination of immigration trends suggests the estimate would be a majority. Until the 2000s, it was estimated that only 3% of the Black population was foreign born (Gambino, Trevelyan, and Fitzwater, 2014). Today, the number has grown to 9%. Furthermore, an estimated 7 million, or nearly one in five, Black citizens alive in 2014 were born before the passages of the 1964 Civil Rights Act, according to estimates based on data from the US Census Annual Estimates of the Resident Population by Sex, Age, Race, and Hispanic Origin for the United States: April 1, 2010, to July 1, 2014.
5. This reference to a civil rights leader is brief and appears in a nonpolitical context. But it serves to highlight how a legacy of the civil rights struggle is embedded in even the most basic decisions and descriptions by Black respondents. The owner of this statement, Royce, consciously wears a pair of glasses that make him look and feel like Malcolm X. These glasses are an enduring symbol of the antiestablishment civil rights leader, a symbol that scholar Carol Tulloch describes as the iconography of Malcolm X. She explains, “A solitary pair of horn-rimmed glasses initiates a ricochet of image references, teachings, and beliefs that is Malcolm X” (Tulloch, 2000, 306). Even Malcolm X recognized the importance of his glasses for his life and identity. In his autobiography, he describes his first purchases after being released from prison in 1952: “I remember well. I bought a better-looking pair of eyeglasses than the pair the prison had issued me; and I bought a suitcase and a wristwatch. I have thought since, that without fully knowing it, I was preparing for what my life was about to become. Because those are three things I’ve used more than anything else” (X and Haley, 1968, 289). This is a statement Royce is familiar with—he read it in Malcolm X’s autobiography.
6. All names of interviewees are pseudonyms, and the details of occupations have been changed slightly to protect the identity of the respondents.
7. Immigrants from these four countries of origin, along with Vietnam and Korea, comprise 83% of the Asian American population in the United States today (*The Rise of Asian Americans*, 2012).
8. The connection between cultural activities and honoring the past was quite rare among Black Americans I talked with, but Dawson (2003) suggests that there have been times in the nation’s history when this connection, especially to African heritage, was much more common.
9. In the face of these continued challenges and barriers, scholars remain conflicted about the extent to which Black America has moved toward financial parity with Whites (e.g., Dawson, 1994; Hochschild, Weaver, and Burch, 2012; Pettit, 2012; Wilson, 2011, 2012).
10. Martin and Royce were also the two most ideologically conservative Black respondents I talked with, both admitting to not having voted for Barack Obama in at least one presidential bid. This suggests that ideology, in addition to race, may shape the expression of the helping hands norm.
11. There does, however, exist wide variation in income and education by country of origin, and a broader share of Asian Americans than non-Hispanic Whites live below the poverty line (*Immigrants in the United States*, 2018; Wong et al., 2011).